

BOOK REVIEWS

T.C. Winebrenner, Editor

Govier, Trudy. *A Practical Study of Argument*. 5th ed. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth, 2001. 496 pages. \$69.95 paper. ISBN 0-534-51976-8.

Moore, Brooke Noel and Richard Parker. *Critical Thinking*. 6th ed. Burr Ridge, IL: McGraw-Hill, 2001. 522 pages. \$64.30 paper. ISBN 0-767-41067-X.

Trudy Govier's *A Practical Study of Argument* and Brooke Moore and Richard Parker's *Critical Thinking* both reflect an informal reasoning approach to the study of argument. Both textbooks treat arguments as objects embodying correct inferences as opposed to a more rhetorically-oriented understanding of arguments as matters of appropriate judgment and communicative skill. While both textbooks are geared toward the same type of critical thinking course, and hence cover much of the same territory, their methods of covering this material differ in style and emphasis.

Govier's text is more explicitly focused on arguments as the engine that drives critical thinking. Her textbook is arranged first to describe what arguments are, then to instruct readers in the analysis of arguments, and finally to delineate the methods of evaluating arguments. The movement from definition through analysis to evaluation occurs within the first three chapters of the text. By focusing quickly and exclusively on the study of arguments, Govier dispenses with contextualizing arguments within the subject of critical thinking; for Govier, justifying claims with good reasons is critical thinking. Chapter three foreshadows the remainder of the book by introducing the mnemonic "A-R-G" – an evaluative calculus composed of three tests: acceptability of premises (A), relevance of premises to conclusions (R), and sufficiency of grounds (G). Arguments that pass these three tests, she instructs, are cogent arguments.

While the third chapter introduces the notion of cogency, the remainder of the book elaborates the individual standards of evaluation. The next three chapters explain elements of cogency common to all arguments: language use, acceptability of premises, and relevance of premises to conclusions. The test for sufficiency of grounds, however, is not focused into a single chapter because sufficiency varies according to the type of inference employed in an argument. Hence, Govier devotes most of the remainder of the book to the different types of

associative reasoning and how sufficiency is embodied in each inference type. She includes chapters on deductive arguments (categorical and propositional logics), inductive arguments (generalizations and causal arguments), analogies, and conductive arguments (arguments that use a number of independent premises to support a conclusion) and the role of counter-considerations in argument. The final chapter functions as a capstone to the textbook by explaining analysis and evaluation of longer arguments.

Govier's approach ranges over the traditional material of informal logic, but always is framed by the theme of argument evaluation. Her evaluative scheme follows a clear and familiar sequence of identification, analysis, and evaluation in which each step is a foundation upon which the next step proceeds. At the same time, by moving quickly to evaluation, Govier positions the evaluation of arguments front-and-center as the primary endeavor of her text and of critical thinking.

Govier's grouping of inductive forms of reasoning – causal, generalization, and analogical – into two chapters is curious and perhaps problematic. Naturally, there is a connection between reasoning by generalization and causal reasoning in that arguers frequently use generalizations as premises to support causal claims. However, Govier's decision to combine these two forms of reasoning into a single chapter, while setting aside analogical reasoning as its own chapter, means that the similarities between generalizations and analogies are ignored, and that the complexity and uniqueness of causal reasoning is given short shrift.

Both textbooks similarly cover much of the ground necessary for any effective critical thinking course: language use, inductive arguments and deductive reasoning. The main distinction between *A Practical Study of Argument* and *Critical Thinking*, however, is that Govier emphasizes analysis and evaluation of argument as indicative of critical thinking, while Moore and Parker treat arguments as but one element of a more inclusive conception of critical thinking.

Moore and Parker's text is more focused on the art of thinking and inference-making. The arrangement of their textbook starts with the individual components of critical thinking and builds those components into more and more complex thinking procedures until they arrive at arguments. The first section outlines their approach to critical thinking by defining it and developing the relationship between critical thinking and writing well. From there they move into a second section focusing on claims. This section includes two chapters on informative claims and explanations, but also includes three chapters on problematic

elements of thinking such as inappropriate language use, fallacious appeals, and faulty inferences. The third section of the book involves six chapters dealing with arguments *per se*. The first chapter in this section explains the anatomy of arguments and explores basic tenets of argument evaluation. There are two chapters on deductive reasoning (categorical logic and truth-functional logic), a chapter on inductive arguments (generalizations and analogical reasoning), a chapter on causal arguments, and a final chapter on moral, legal, and aesthetic reasoning.

Moore and Parker have succeeded in writing a user-friendly textbook for both students and instructors. This is especially noteworthy given that many students often find the subject of critical thinking dry and abstract. For one thing, their text is written in an easy-to-read style. It also includes numerous sidebars that, more often than not, entertain and illustrate their main points well; frequently the sidebars are extreme and absurd examples of the critical thinking difficulties being explained in the text, which are both entertaining and pedagogically valuable. One of the strongest aspects of the Moore and Parker text is the astounding wealth of examples and exercises available to the instructor. These examples and exercises are in the book itself and two ancillary books: an instructor's manual prepared by Moore and Parker, and a student's study guide authored by Nickolas Pappas.

Moore and Parker's focus on inference-making, not to mention their organizational approach of making arguments the culminating construct of individual judgment-making processes, frames critical thinking as a cognitive skill rather than a communicative skill. Hence, this textbook may not be entirely appropriate for those argumentation courses where the instructor views the distinction between cognition and expression as problematic. Furthermore, their inclusion of fallacious appeals and faulty inferences in the section on claims, instead of placing it in the section on arguments, may be justifiable but is nonetheless counterintuitive for instructors of argument given that inferences usually are considered a definitive element of arguments.

Perhaps the most disappointing aspect of Moore and Parker's textbook is that it embodies a hostile tone towards rhetorical practice. This tone should give pause to any communication instructor considering this textbook. Their hostile tone is most apparent in the chapter titles of the sixth edition. The fourth chapter on language use, for example, is titled "Persuasion Through Rhetoric" by which rhetoric is equated with traditional language fallacies such as innuendo, ambiguity, and euphemism. The following two chapters on fallacious reasoning are titled "More Rhetorical Devices" and "More Pseudoreasoning and

Other Rhetorical Ploys.” In the introduction to the fourth chapter they refer to these elements as “rhetorical gimmickry” or “spin” and they explicitly use the term “rhetoric” to represent the negative connotations of these so-called techniques (117).

Moore and Parker’s denigration of rhetoric is based on their perception that rhetoric functions mainly as an impediment to good argument; rhetoric, they claim, “often is used as a substitute for argument” (117). Clearly, their act of naming and their underlying ideology fails to appreciate the complexity and subtlety of the art of rhetoric, and especially the centrality of rhetoric as the foundation of argument rather than as its substitute. Especially disheartening is the fact that this hostile tone is new to the sixth edition. The previous edition referred to many of these problematic forms of reasoning with less inflammatory labels such as “Nonargumentative Persuasion” and “Pseudoreasoning.” In the preface to the sixth edition they claim to use the negatively connotated word rhetoric in order to avoid ambiguities that had plagued previous editions. Their desired success at clarity is clouded, however, by their misrepresentation that echoes a standard philosophical attitude toward rhetoric: rhetoric as impediment to effective thinking and communication. In short, Moore and Parker’s attitude fails to consider rhetoric’s more realistic and contemporary conception of arguments as claims and justifications adapted to varying issues and contexts.

These reservations aside, both textbooks are thorough introductions to argument as manifestations of claims, support, and inferences. Both texts focus almost exclusively on the *logos* of argument and, as a result, provide a thorough foundation in aspects of associative reasoning and inference-making. Both of these books are appropriate for argument classes whose primary purpose is to explore associative reasoning as a fundamental element of thinking and arguing.

Both texts’ exclusive focus on the *logos* of argument, however, might also be an obstacle in more rhetorically inclined courses in argumentation. By focusing exclusively on reasoning, these texts are unable to consider larger (and, again, more contextual) questions of analyzing issues, developing cases, or judging appropriate arguments for specific and varying situations. Moore and Parker address the topic of issues briefly, devoting only six pages to it in the first chapter. Govier’s table of contents and index do not even contain the word “issue”. Both textbooks approach the subject of argument through the lens of logical coherence rather than framing arguments as a tool for identifying and judging questions of issue, appropriateness, and context. In short, both textbooks focus on arguments and not on argumentation. Only in the final chapter of Moore and Parker’s book do they approach a more contextual understanding of argument with their chapter on moral, legal, and aesthetic

reasoning. (Tellingly, this last chapter was not authored by Moore and Parker but rather by Nina Rosenstand and Anita Silvers.) Furthermore, placement of this chapter at the end of the text creates the impression that the contextual study of argument is an afterthought rather than an integral part of their system of critical thinking.

Another concern with both textbooks (and, I suspect, with a number of other critical thinking textbooks) is their relative neglect of larger-scale arguments. Again, the amount of space devoted to this topic is indicative. Moore and Parker's second chapter on "Critical Thinking and Clear Writing" connects the study of argument to larger essays, but here they focus only on clarity of organization and language use. Govier does not completely ignore the issue of larger-scale arguments given that her final chapter is on "Reflective Analysis of Longer Works." Yet her treatment of this aspect of argument is tentative. Her instructions in "selectively" reading essays to find core arguments and major lines of reasoning are brief. Her evaluative criteria for longer arguments, which include standards such as clarity and organization, balance, word choice, and impact (418-419), do not evolve smoothly from the A-R-G standards that the rest of the textbook is built upon. In short, both textbooks are helpful, but ultimately inadequate, at helping students understand how to read larger arguments for their core propositions and lines of reasoning.

Both books will help students understand the mechanics of argument analysis when reading or hearing short arguments comprised of a handful of claims and premises. *A Practical Study of Argument* is the most likely to be of use in an argument course since it focuses exclusively on the identification, analysis, and evaluation of arguments. *Critical Thinking* may be less appropriate for an argument course because, even though it does deal with arguments, it does so mainly as a component of critical thinking rather than as a subject of its own. By using either of these books, however, students and instructors will need to apply their understanding of arguments-as-objects to the larger, more life-like, more sophisticated, more complex, more subtle, and, ultimately, more rhetorical realms of understanding, making, and adapting arguments to different cultures, different spheres and fields, about different issues, to different audiences. Clearly, these textbooks are more about arguments than they are about the social and cultural processes of argumentation.

Alan Razee

California Polytechnic State University, San Luis Obispo

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